

Get Ready for Professional Work

A 30-minute check to do **before the first session**. You already know Photoshop; this makes sure your copy, your screen, and your files are ready for 16-bit masking, real color management, and client-style deliverables, so Session 1 starts with a landscape rescue instead of an update bar.

 ~30 min + any update

Assumes intro-level Photoshop

Windows or macOS

PLEASE FINISH THIS BEFORE CLASS

Updates and sign-ins can take a while. If you get stuck on a step, note where and we'll sort it out in Session 1's setup check. But please **try** before you arrive.

ARE YOU READY FOR THIS COURSE?

This course starts where an introductory Photoshop course ends. You should already be comfortable with the skills below. If two or more feel shaky, work through the free **Photoshop: From First Win to Finished Work** course (rays-photoshop-intro.netlify.app) first, or at least its Modules 1–4.

- ◆ Adjustment layers and **layer masks**: black hides, white reveals, gray partly reveals
- ◆ Selections with Select Subject and **Select & Mask**, output to a layer mask
- ◆ **Camera Raw** and **Curves** for global tone and color
- ◆ **Smart Objects** and Smart Filters
- ◆ Basic healing, a simple composite, and saving a layered `.psd` plus a flat export

WHAT YOU NEED

- ◆ A **laptop or desktop** running Windows or macOS that runs the current Photoshop comfortably (see **Hardware Notes**), plus its charger.
- ◆ **Adobe Photoshop 2025 or newer**, the desktop app, current release recommended. Photoshop on the web, on iPad, and Photoshop Elements are **not** enough for this course.
- ◆ An **Adobe account** with a plan that includes Photoshop, **Adobe Fonts** (Session 5), and **generative credits** (Session 6).

- ◆ **A mouse or pen tablet.** Masking, retouching, and dodge & burn need precise strokes; a tablet helps most in Session 3.
- ◆ **A notebook or a text file** for your learning journal. It feeds your capstone case study in Session 8.
- ◆ **Your own images** (see **What Images to Bring**). Practice files are provided for every lab.

SET UP IN 5 STEPS

1 Update Photoshop

~5 min + update

- 1 Open the **Creative Cloud desktop app** and sign in. Under **Apps ► Updates**, install any Photoshop update.
- 2 Open Photoshop and check the version: **Help ► About Photoshop** (Windows) or **Photoshop ► About Photoshop** (macOS). It should say **2025** or newer.
- 3 If Photoshop asks you to sign in or accept terms, do it now, not in class.

2 Reset the workspace and check the GPU

~5 min

- 1 **Window ► Workspace ► Essentials (Default)**, then **Window ► Workspace ► Reset Essentials**, so the demos match your screen. Save your own workspace first if you have one you love: **Window ► Workspace ► New Workspace**.
- 2 Open **Window ► Channels**, **Window ► Histogram**, and **Window ► Info**, and dock them. You will use them in almost every session.
- 3 In Preferences (**Edit ► Preferences** on Windows, **Photoshop ► Settings** on macOS) ► **Performance**, make sure **Use Graphics Processor** is on. Perspective Warp (Session 4) and several other tools are grayed out without it.

SHARED OR BORROWED COMPUTER?

If tools behave strangely, reset preferences: **Preferences ► General ► Reset Preferences On Quit**, then quit and reopen. This never touches your files.

3

Set a few recommended preferences

~5 min

- ◆ **File Handling:** turn on **Automatically Save Recovery Information Every 10 Minutes**, and save working files to **your computer**, not as cloud documents. Set **Maximize PSD and PSB File Compatibility** to **Always** or **Ask**.
- ◆ **Performance:** let Photoshop use about **70%** of your memory, and set **History States** to at least **50**.
- ◆ **Units & Rulers:** set Rulers to **Pixels**. If you change it for a lesson, change it back afterward: several steps and the Session 6 script assume pixels.
- ◆ **Color Settings:** open **Edit ► Color Settings** and note which RGB working space it shows. **Don't change it yet**. We check it together in Session 1 and set it up properly in Session 2.

WINDOWS VS MAC KEYS

The course writes shortcuts as **Ctrl/⌘** and **Alt/⌥**: use Ctrl and Alt on Windows, ⌘ Command and ⌥ Option on a Mac.

4

Create a course folder

~5 min

Professional work keeps originals, layered masters, and deliverables apart. The capstone case study (Session 8) also needs your "before" files and screenshots, so start saving them now.

```
photoshop-intermediate/  
├─ originals/      ← copies of your images; never edit these  
├─ session-1/      ← working .psd masters and exports for Session 1  
├─ session-2/  
│   ...  
├─ session-8/      ← your capstone  
└─ journal.txt     ← or a paper notebook
```

ONE RULE THAT SAVES HEADACHES

Always work on **copies**, and batch-process only copies (Session 6). Name files in lowercase with hyphens, the way the lessons do (`luminosity-working.psd` , `cutout-working.psd`).

- 1 **File ► Open** a photo from `originals/`, then **Image ► Mode ► 16 Bits/Channel**. The title bar should now show **RGB/16**.
- 2 In the Channels panel, **Ct r l / ⌘**-click the **RGB** thumbnail. Marching ants should appear around the bright areas: that's your first luminosity selection. Deselect.
- 3 **File ► Save As ► Photoshop (.psd)** into `session-1/` as `test-working.psd`, choosing **Save on your computer** if asked.
- 4 Look under **Edit** for **Generative Fill** (grayed out until you make a selection; that's normal). If it's missing, or your account shows no generative credits, tell us before Session 6.
- 5 Close the file.

✓ **YOU'RE READY**

If you saved a 16-bit `.psd` to your own folder, you're set for Session 1.

WHAT IMAGES TO BRING

Practice files are provided for every lab, but your portfolio is better with your own work. Bring **copies** at full original size (RAW welcome), not screenshots or images saved from social media, and bring them on your computer, not only on your phone.

SESSION	BRING	WHY
S1	A high-contrast landscape (bright sky, dark ground); a bare tree, power lines, or another intricate subject against a plain bright sky; a portrait with loose or curly hair on a fairly plain background	Luminosity & channel masks, the hard cutout
S2	A favorite photo to grade (a portrait is ideal); a second shot from the same set in different light; one deliberately vivid image. If you print with a lab, the profile it asks for	Color management, grading, soft-proofing
S3	A portrait of someone who has agreed to be retouched and shown in class, or a self-portrait: large original, flat-ish light, teeth and loose hair visible. No beauty-filtered photos, and no children	High-end retouching

SESSION	BRING	WHY
S4	A background with clear perspective and visible shadows (a street, room, tiled floor, or table), and a clean cutout from your Session 1 work. Optional: a glossy surface and a deep scene	Commercial compositing
S5	Your Session 4 key visual as key art. Optional: your own logo as a transparent PNG	Type systems & a campaign
S6	Your layered Session 4 composite (or a cramped, busy photo); a folder of 8–12 photo copies , a mix of landscape and portrait; a short real list (a roster or lineup) with photos you may use	Generative tools & automation
S7	A simple layered design to animate (your Session 5 master works); optional: your own pan, exposure bracket, or focus series; one or two capstone ideas with reference images	Multi-shot, animation, capstone kickoff
S8	Your capstone master and versions, brief, moodboard, and end-of-pass screenshots, built as homework after Session 7	Studio, case study, presentation

CONSENT AND RIGHTS

Only retouch or show people who have said yes, or yourself. Don't bring confidential or client work. For your capstone, use images you made or have the right to use, check the license on any stock, and use fonts you're licensed to use.

HARDWARE NOTES

- ◆ **Check Adobe's current system requirements** before you buy or install anything. They change with each release.
- ◆ **Memory:** this course works in 16-bit with many layers. **16 GB of RAM** is strongly recommended; 8 GB will struggle in Sessions 3, 4, and 7.
- ◆ **Disk space:** keep 30 GB or more free on your main drive for Photoshop's scratch disk and 16-bit masters.
- ◆ **Graphics:** update your graphics drivers, and keep Use Graphics Processor on (step 2).
- ◆ **Screen:** 1920 × 1080 or larger. For color-critical work, a **calibrated** monitor makes grading decisions trustworthy; a hardware calibrator is a good investment but not required.
- ◆ **Color:** turn off **Night Light** (Windows) or **Night Shift / True Tone** (macOS) during class. They tint your screen and will mislead your color decisions.

ACCESSIBILITY

Tell us before Session 1 if anything would make the course easier for you. A few things that already help:

- ◆ **Bigger interface:** raise UI Font Size or UI Scaling in Preferences ► Interface.
- ◆ **Color vision differences:** the **Info** panel shows exact values under your cursor, the Histogram and Channels show tone without relying on hue, and **View ► Proof Setup** includes color-blindness previews. The color sessions lean on numbers you can read, not only on what looks right.
- ◆ **Keyboard over precise mousing:** most tools have single-key shortcuts, collected in the lessons' recipe cards and the online Recipes II library.
- ◆ **Screen readers:** Photoshop is highly visual with limited screen-reader support. Please talk to us so we can plan alternatives together.
- ◆ **Pace and breaks:** every session has a break, and every lesson stays online, in light or dark mode, to revisit at your own speed.

FREQUENTLY ASKED

◆ I LEARNED PHOTOSHOP ON MY OWN. AM I READY?

Probably, if you can do everything in **Are You Ready for This Course?** without looking it up. Masks and Smart Objects are the two that matter most.

◆ CAN I USE AN OLDER PHOTOSHOP OR PHOTOSHOP ELEMENTS?

Please don't. The generative and Harmonize tools in Session 6 need a current release, and Elements lacks channels, Curves, Variables, and much of what this course teaches.

◆ DO I NEED TO SHOOT RAW?

No, but RAW files and 16-bit editing give you more room in Sessions 1–3. High-quality JPEGs work for every lab.

◆ WHAT ARE GENERATIVE CREDITS?

Generative tools run in Adobe's cloud and use credits that come with most Photoshop plans. Check your balance before Session 6. School or company accounts sometimes have generative features turned off by an administrator; check early.

◆ WHAT IF I CAN'T FINISH THE SETUP?

Come anyway. Note where you got stuck; Session 1 opens with a setup check.